

NEU/NYP Archive Project

A proposal to the Unit Chief

September 29, 2026 · Prepared by **Josh**

Purpose

The Unit's archive room holds records and media that exist nowhere else, and some of that material is degrading on a fixed clock. This proposal offers to digitize it, catalog it, and publish an approved portion as a public archive site. It is offered as volunteer work.

Four outcomes:

- **Preserve** the at-risk formats first. Film, slides, and magnetic tape fail in ways paper does not.
- **Catalog** every item into a searchable database, with a full copy delivered to the Unit.
- **Publish** only what the Unit approves, through a review gate the Unit holds.
- **Tell the stories** — feature pieces in the model of the Iron Mike story, plus structured ways for retirees, families, and current crews to contribute.

The ask at the end of this document is deliberately small: permission to run one pilot batch under signed custody paperwork, then meet and decide whether anything continues.

What is in the room today

I have already surveyed the room at shelf level, so what follows is based on what is actually there rather than on assumptions. The written inventory is available to the Unit on request, independent of anything else in this proposal.

The holdings run across these kinds of material:

Category	Typical material
Incident records	ICS packets, 209s, 214s, unit logs, IAPs
Station and battalion records	Daily logs, station histories, rosters, correspondence
Photographs	Prints, negatives, contact sheets
Slides	35mm transparencies
Moving image	16mm reels, VHS, possibly Betacam or U-matic
Maps and plans	Fire maps, pre-plans, station drawings, oversized sheets
Apparatus and equipment	Engine and dozer records, photographs, specifications
Publications	Newsletters, clippings, training material, memorabilia

The room is inside a secured area, which shapes the whole handling question addressed further down. Nothing in this proposal requires unescorted access or access to any other part of the facility.

Why some of this is urgent and most of it is not

Paper in a dry, stable room can wait another twenty years. Film, slides, and magnetic tape cannot, and that asymmetry is the single most important fact in this proposal.

- **Acetate film** breaks down into acetic acid — "vinegar syndrome." Once it starts it accelerates, and it is not reversible.
- **Color slides and prints** lose their dyes, which is why 1970s and 1980s fire photos so often look orange.
- **Videotape** sheds its magnetic layer onto the playback heads. A tape can often be played once more, and not twice.
- **Playback hardware and vendors** are disappearing. Fewer shops every year can transfer 16mm or Betacam at archival quality.

So the moving-image and slide material gets triaged early, even though paper is the bulk of the collection and the easier win. That is why the phasing below does film and tape before finishing the paper.

What the public would see

A fast, searchable archive site that works as well on a phone in a station kitchen as on a desktop. Not a folder of PDFs on a web server — a real catalog with a reading experience.

What a visitor can do:

- **Search everything**, including the text inside scanned documents, which are run through OCR on ingest.
- **Browse by incident, station, battalion, or year** — pick a fire by name and see every document, photo, and map tied to it in one place.
- **View media properly** — deep-zoom on scans and photographs, an inline player for transferred film and video.
- **Read feature stories** — curated pieces built from the archive. The Iron Mike story is the model and the proof the format works.

It would be a progressive web app: loads fast, works on bad cell service, pins to a phone home screen. Nothing about it runs on agency infrastructure or touches the agency network.

Precedent: this has been done before

This is a well-worn path, not an experiment. Comparable efforts, all of them public agency records made public:

Agency or project	What they did
Indianapolis Fire Department	Log books, dispatch recordings, personnel records, newsletters, and photographs back to the 1870s, digitized in partnership with the Indianapolis Public Library and published on its Digital Indy site — roughly 80,000 scans and 4,660 staff hours
Los Angeles County Fire Museum	Early L.A. County Fire Department papers scanned at high resolution with OCR into searchable PDFs, through a commercial digitization partner

Agency or project	What they did
Seattle Fire Department	Department central files, 1890–2003, described and served through the Seattle Municipal Archives digital collections
U.S. Forest Service	"Hidden Photo History of the Forest Service and Wildland Fire, 1910–2010" — roughly 5,000 photographs plus 8mm and 16mm film, covering the 1910 fires, early California air patrols, and Mann Gulch
National Museum of Forest Service History	A dedicated wildland fire history repository, now anchored by a new conservation legacy center in Missoula
California Revealed	A California State Library program that digitizes, preserves, and hosts archival and audiovisual material for local libraries, archives, museums, and historical societies — over 200 partners statewide

Two things worth pulling out of that list.

First, none of these appear to have produced a privacy incident. The model is established and the safeguards are known, which is most of why the next sections are as specific as they are.

Second, **California Revealed is worth a phone call regardless of what happens with this proposal.** It is State Library funded, it specializes in exactly the at-risk film and tape formats sitting in that room, and digitization is free to partner organizations. The usual route in is a partnership with a public library or historical society rather than a direct agency application — so it is not a replacement for this proposal, but it is a real preservation path for the most fragile material, and it costs the Unit nothing to ask.

How the collection is organized

Two structures doing two different jobs. The hierarchy records where something came from. The facets let a retired captain find the one fire he remembers.

[Figure: archive structure · four levels of description, six cross-cutting facets — see the online version of this document]

The hierarchy follows standard archival practice — provenance and original order are preserved, so an item's context survives digitization. A worked path reads:

NEU/NYP Archive → Stations → Station 20 → Photographs → item NEU-2026-00417

The facets are where the real work happens for a fire unit. Almost nobody arriving at this archive is looking for "Series: Incident Records." They are looking for a fire by name, a station they were assigned to, a year, an engine number, or a person. Every item carries as many facets as are known, and any combination of them is a valid search.

Series are described consistently across record groups, so a photograph from HQ is cataloged the same way as one from a station. That consistency is what makes cross-cutting search work at all.

How material moves in and out

The proposal is a small-batch loan with a signed receipt in both directions, and no more than a few boxes out of the room at any one time. The design goal is that at every moment, the Unit can say exactly what is out, who has it, and when it is due back.

1. **Request.** I identify a batch from the survey — two to four boxes, or one media tote — and send the proposed contents to the Unit point of contact for approval.
2. **Pickup.** The Unit representative and I sign a Custody Receipt listing containers and contents at folder level. I photograph each container as received, including any existing damage.
3. **Storage and work.** One controlled indoor location, no third-party access, nothing loaned onward, nothing left in a vehicle. Scanning on my own equipment. Original order preserved — nothing unstapled, trimmed, or reordered without specific permission.
4. **Return.** Within the agreed window, typically two to four weeks. Both parties sign the return side of the same receipt, and I attach a **Returned Batch Report**: what was scanned, what was too fragile and why, what was found that the manifest did not list, and anything that arrived already damaged.
5. **Next batch.** Nothing new leaves until the previous batch is back and signed in. One batch out at a time keeps the accounting trivial.

If the Chief prefers that nothing leaves the building, I will work on-site with a portable scanner during agreed windows. It is slower, it needs a place to set up, and somebody has to let me in and out — which is the personnel draw I am trying to avoid. I will work either way; the small-batch loan is simply the version that costs the Unit less.

The paperwork that makes custody defensible

The closest familiar analogy is **chain of custody** — the evidence transfer model, where every hand-off is signed, timed, and traceable. That instinct is correct, and the mechanism proposed here works the same way. But evidence rules are not the right legal vehicle for archival records, so the instruments below are the ones actually used for this kind of work.

Instrument	What it does	Who signs
Volunteer Services Agreement	Establishes me as an authorized volunteer of the Unit for this project, with a defined scope	Unit, volunteer
Memorandum of Understanding	States the project's purpose, boundaries, deliverables, the Unit's approval authority, ownership of the output, and how the arrangement ends	Unit, volunteer
Temporary Custody Agreement	Governs off-site work: storage conditions, transport, insurance or liability position, duration, prohibition on onward transfer	Unit, volunteer
Custody Receipt / Transfer of Materials	Per-batch, signed at pickup and again at return — the chain-of-custody log for this project	Unit rep, volunteer, both directions
Returned Batch Report	Attached to each return: what was scanned, what was not, what was found, condition notes	Volunteer, acknowledged by Unit rep

Four points that matter to the Chief:

- **These stay State records.** Nothing here transfers ownership. Under the State Records Management Act and CAL FIRE's retention schedule the Unit remains custodian of record. I hold temporary physical custody, and a digital copy is a copy — not a replacement.
- **Nothing is destroyed, discarded, or reorganized.** If I think something should be reboxed or rehoused, I say so in the batch report and leave it alone. Disposition belongs to the Unit and its records coordinator.
- **Attach to what already exists, and have it reviewed.** CAL FIRE already has volunteer instruments and a records management structure, and hanging this off those is faster and less exposed than drafting something new. The framing above is practical, not legal advice — the records coordinator and legal should approve the final documents before the first box moves.

One thing to confirm before anything moves: whether any of it is under a litigation hold, an open investigation, or a retention obligation that puts it off-limits. That is a Unit call, and the inventory makes it straightforward to answer shelf by shelf.

What gets published, and what does not

Everything is ingested private by default, and only the Unit can make something public. I do not hold the release decision, and the system is built so that I cannot accidentally hold it.

Old fire records routinely contain material that should not go on a public website:

- Personnel information — evaluations, discipline, medical, home addresses, Social Security numbers on older forms
- Patient and EMS detail in incident records
- Civilian names, addresses, and property loss detail
- Arson and cause-and-origin investigation material, including closed cases
- Images of fatalities or serious injury, and anything touching ongoing litigation or claims

The pipeline that handles it:

1. **Ingest private.** Every item lands with review status **unreviewed**, visible only to authenticated project accounts.
2. **First-pass flag.** I flag anything matching the categories above, plus anything I am unsure about. Unsure defaults to flagged.
3. **Unit review.** A Unit-designated reviewer works an approval queue — approve, withhold, or approve with redaction. A few clicks per item, at their own pace, and nothing expires waiting.
4. **Publish.** Only approved items become publicly visible. Where one name or address is the only problem, the public copy can be masked and the unredacted master stays private.
5. **Takedown path.** A visible contact route for anyone — family, retiree, employee — to ask that an item be pulled. Pulled first, discussed after.

Borderline items escalate through the Unit's own channels — PIO, records coordinator, or Sacramento as the Chief directs. The California Public Records Act exemptions that would apply to a records request apply just

as much to a voluntary publication, and the conservative reading wins. A withheld item is still preserved and still cataloged for the Unit, which is most of the value here regardless.

Protected health information and personnel records: never published

Two categories are structurally excluded from the public site, regardless of the age of the record.

Protected health information. Patient names, ages, addresses, conditions, treatment, and transport destinations; any EMS or medical narrative inside an incident record; anything that would identify a person receiving care. Where PHI sits inside an otherwise publishable document — a patient name written on an incident report — the public copy is redacted and the unredacted master stays private. No medical information about any member of the public or any employee is published, ever.

Personnel and HR information. Performance evaluations, discipline, complaints and investigations, grievances, workers' compensation and injury records, medical and fitness-for-duty files, home addresses, personal phone numbers, dates of birth, and the Social Security numbers that appear on older forms. Employment information about sworn members appears only where it is already public record, and only in a historical, non-derogatory context — a roster, a promotion, a retirement, a commendation.

These are not reviewer judgment calls made item by item. They are exclusions applied at ingest: the material is withheld entirely or redacted before anything reaches a public URL. HIPAA where it applies, the Information Practices Act, and the CPRA personnel and medical exemptions all point the same direction, and where the reading is ambiguous the item stays private. Nothing gets published to settle an argument about whether an exemption technically applies.

How the platform enforces it

The site runs on Supabase — Postgres with authentication, authorization, and storage access control built in. The safeguards that matter here:

- **Row Level Security.** Every item carries a review status, and the database itself decides what an anonymous visitor may read. The default is deny. An item becomes publicly readable only after a Unit reviewer has explicitly approved it. A bug in the website cannot leak an unapproved record, because the public role has no permission to see it in the first place.
- **Separate public and private storage.** Public derivatives live in a public bucket. Masters, unredacted originals, and anything unreviewed live in a private bucket reachable only through a short-lived signed URL issued to an authenticated account. Nothing sensitive sits behind a guessable link.
- **Encryption and backups.** Encrypted in transit and at rest, with automated backups and point-in-time recovery. Master files are additionally kept on offline storage I control, so a platform problem is not a data loss event.
- **Named accounts, no shared logins, full audit trail.** Every approve, withhold, and redact action is attributed to a named person with a timestamp. If anyone ever asks who released a given document, the answer is on record.
- **Withheld means invisible, not merely unavailable.** A withheld item does not appear in the public catalog or the public search index at all. The site does not advertise the existence of a sealed file.

A withheld item is still fully described in the Unit's private catalog, which is where its value to the Unit lives anyway.

What this asks of the Unit

The total ongoing ask is on the order of an hour a month from one person, and it is the part of this proposal I have worked hardest to keep small.

What	Roughly how much
A named point of contact who can approve and sign for batches	15–20 minutes per batch, a handful of batches a year
Escorted access to the archive room for pickups and returns	One visit per batch
Sign-off on the custody paperwork, once, via the records coordinator and legal	One review cycle up front
A reviewer for the publish queue	Self-paced; nothing expires waiting
A decision on Unit branding, disclaimer, and attribution language	One conversation

What this does **not** ask for:

- No funding — hosting, equipment, software, and vendor transfer costs are mine.
- No staff time for scanning, sorting, indexing, or data entry.
- No IT resources, no network access, no agency devices, no accounts on agency systems.
- No use of the CAL FIRE seal or official marks without explicit approval. The site can carry a clear "unofficial volunteer project" disclaimer if the Chief prefers.

Technology, standards, and cost

The stack is deliberately boring and cheap, and the Unit is never locked into it or into me.

Piece	What it is	Why
Netlify	Static site hosting with a global CDN	Fast, inexpensive, nothing to patch or maintain
Supabase	PostgreSQL catalog, authentication, file storage	Standard Postgres — the data is portable to anything
Derivative image tiles	Pre-generated zoom levels for scans and photos	Deep-zoom viewing without large downloads
OCR on ingest	Searchable text extracted from every scanned document	Full-text search is what makes an archive usable
Off-site backup	Nightly copy of the database and the master files	A single point of failure is not acceptable for one-of-a-kind material

Preservation practice. Masters are captured to archival specification — lossless TIFF for documents and photographs, following the federal FADGI guidelines the National Archives and Library of Congress use. Film and videotape go to a professional transfer vendor, not hobbyist equipment. Public files are derivatives; masters are never discarded to save space.

Metadata. The catalog schema maps to Dublin Core, so the whole thing can be exported and handed to the California State Archives or a professional archivist later without a migration project. Appendix B lists the fields.

The Unit gets everything. On request at any time, and automatically at the end of each phase: master files, a database export, and the documentation needed to stand the site up elsewhere. If I disappear tomorrow, the Unit has the archive.

Cost. Low tens of dollars a month at the scale this collection implies, absorbed by me. The one item that could become material is professional film and tape transfer, which is priced per reel. I will bring vendor quotes against the actual reel and tape counts; if the volume warrants outside funding, that becomes a separate conversation about grants or a historical society partnership — not a bill to the Unit.

Name, domain, and funding

The domain. A [.org](#) sets the right expectation: non-commercial, archival, and not posing as an official CAL FIRE property. Candidates:

- [nypfirearchive.org](#)
- [neufirecache.org](#)
- [nyparchives.org](#)
- [neufirearchive.org](#)

My own preference is [nypfirearchive.org](#) — it says exactly what the thing is, and NYP is what the people who worked here actually call it. [neufirecache.org](#) is the better name if the Unit wants something with more character to it. Either way the name, and whether the Unit's identity appears on it at all, is the Chief's call. If the answer is a plain disclaimer and no CAL FIRE marks, the site works fine that way.

Funding. I am absorbing the cost, and at the scale of hosting and a database that is not a meaningful number. Two things could change it: professional film and tape transfer, which is priced per reel and is the one genuinely expensive line item, and master file storage once it grows into the terabytes.

If that happens, the straightforward answer is a small public fundraiser — a GoFundMe or similar — to cover vendor transfer, hosting, and storage. Conditions I would hold myself to, stated here so they are on the record:

- Run by me as a private individual. Not by, for, or on behalf of CAL FIRE, and the Unit neither receives nor administers any funds.
- No use of the CAL FIRE name, seal, or official marks in any solicitation without written approval.
- Public accounting of what came in and what it paid for.
- None of it happens if the Chief would rather it did not. The project then runs at whatever pace my own budget allows, which is slower but not fatal.

The more durable long-term answer, if this grows, is a 501(c)(3) historical society or a partnership with an existing one — which is also what opens the door to real grant funding. The Indianapolis project was grant-funded, and California Revealed exists for precisely this kind of material. That is a later conversation, not part of this ask.

Pace, and the honest constraint

I want to be direct about this rather than discover it later. I manage a development engineering team at ESO as my day job and work as a developer with Western Confluence Group. This project is evenings and weekends. What I can promise is steady, documented progress — not a delivery date, and not a pace anyone should build a plan around.

What that means in practice:

- Phases have scope, not deadlines. Each one finishes when it finishes.
- Progress is visible in the catalog and on the site, so nobody has to ask me for a status update.
- If I go quiet for a month, nothing is at risk — material is either back in the room or under a signed receipt with a return date.

The off-ramp. If my availability changes, or the Chief wants to stop, the Unit keeps the site, the database, the master files, and the documentation, and any material on loan comes back immediately. Everything is written down well enough that another volunteer, a contractor, or a professional archivist can pick it up without starting over. That is a design constraint, not a courtesy.

Making it a living archive, not a digital storage room

A scanned box that nobody reads is only slightly better than a box nobody opens. The part of this project I care most about is the part that brings people back to it.

- **Feature stories.** Written pieces built from the archive, in the model of the Iron Mike story. One good story does more for the Unit's history than a thousand indexed documents.
- **Identify this photo.** A moderated queue of unidentified faces, apparatus, and locations. Retirees know things no finding aid will ever capture, and every contributor is credited.
- **Station pages.** Each station gets its own history, apparatus, and photographs. Current crews can see themselves in a line going back decades — that is a recruitment and morale asset, not just history.
- **Oral histories and family contributions.** Many of the best photographs of this Unit are in retirees' garages, not the archive room. A simple intake path with a plain-language release lets that material come in — scanned and returned, original kept by the family.

All of it runs through the same review gate as everything else. Nothing a member of the public submits appears on the site without approval.

Risks, stated plainly

Risk	Assessment	Mitigation
Damage or loss of irreplaceable originals	Real — though doing nothing also carries risk as the media degrades	Small batches, signed receipts, photographic condition record at pickup, single controlled storage location, fragile items scanned on-site or not at all
Sensitive material published by mistake	The most serious exposure in this project	Default-private ingest, Unit holds the only approve action, conservative flagging, redaction, visible takedown path
Volunteer availability changes	Likely at some point, given the day job	Phase scope with no deadlines, full copy to the Unit at each phase, documentation written for a successor
Dependency on me or on the platform	A real concern for anything one volunteer builds	Standard Postgres and ordinary static hosting, no proprietary formats, Unit holds masters and exports
Read as an official publication, or as a records-request channel	Likely unless addressed	Disclaimer and attribution approved by the Chief and PIO; clear language that CPRA requests route to the Unit's existing process

If this is more than the Unit wants

This document describes the full version. It is not all-or-nothing, and I would rather do a smaller piece properly than push the Unit into something it is not comfortable with.

The parts separate cleanly:

- **Tier 1 — preservation only.** I scan and catalog, the Unit gets the master files and the database, and nothing is ever published anywhere. This is the floor, and it is still most of the value: the material stops being at risk and becomes searchable internally.
- **Tier 2 — preservation plus an internal site.** The same catalog and the same interface, behind a login, for Unit use only. Useful for training, anniversaries, press requests, and simply finding things.
- **Tier 3 — the full public archive.** Everything above, plus an approved public portion, the feature stories, and public contributions.

If the public piece is too far, say so and we do Tier 1 or Tier 2. If the whole thing is more than the Unit wants to take on right now, the shelf inventory I have already done stays with the Unit at no cost and no obligation, and the offer stands whenever it becomes useful. Any individual piece can be held — the public site, the outside contributions, the fundraising, the Unit branding — and the rest still works.

I am not going to be offended by a no, and I am not going to keep pushing. The material matters more than any particular version of this.

What I am asking for now

Not approval of the whole program. Approval of two small, reversible steps, followed by a conversation.

1. **Permission to run one pilot batch.** Two to four boxes plus a small sample of at-risk media, out and back under signed custody paperwork the Unit's records coordinator and legal have approved. I scan it, catalog it, and build the site with that material in it.

2. **Then we meet.** The site exists but stays private — visible only to the Chief and whoever else the Unit wants in. Nothing is public. You look at the real thing, with real Unit material in it, and decide whether it goes further, goes public, or stops.

That means the Unit sees a working product before it commits to anything, and before a single item is visible outside the organization. If the answer after the pilot is no, the cost to the Unit has been one escort visit and one review of some paperwork.

I would also welcome a pointer to whoever the Chief thinks should be in the room for this — the records coordinator, the PIO, a battalion chief with long institutional memory, or a retiree who already knows what is in that room.

Appendix A — Custody Receipt / Transfer of Materials

One form, signed at release and again at return. Field list, ready to be turned into a real form by whoever owns forms at the Unit.

Header

- Batch number (sequential, e.g. NEU-ARC-2026-004)
- Project name and authorizing agreement reference
- Unit and archive room location

Release

- Date and time out
- Container count and container identifiers
- Description of materials, at folder level or item level for media
- Condition notes at release (per container)
- Photographs attached — yes/no, count, file reference
- Known restrictions or handling instructions
- Releasing employee: name, title, signature, date
- Receiving volunteer: name, signature, date
- Agreed return date
- Storage location and handling conditions during custody
- Statement that custody is temporary, ownership is unchanged, and onward transfer is prohibited

Return

- Date and time returned
- Container count returned, reconciled against release
- Condition on return (per container), with any change from release noted
- Discrepancies — items missing, items found not on the manifest

- Returned Batch Report reference number
- Returning volunteer: name, signature, date
- Receiving employee: name, title, signature, date
- Unit acknowledgement that the batch is reconciled and closed

A running log of batch numbers and their status — out, returned, closed — answers "what is out of the room right now" on one page.

Appendix B — The catalog record

Every digitized item gets a record with these fields. The Dublin Core column is what makes the catalog exportable to any standards-based archive later.

Field	Purpose	Dublin Core
Identifier	Permanent unique ID, never reused	identifier
Title	Supplied title, or a described one in brackets if the item has none	title
Record group	Originating office — HQ, battalion, station, camp, program	provenance
Series	Incident records, station logs, photographs, moving image, maps, apparatus, rosters, publications	—
Document type	Form or genre — ICS 209, daily log, photograph, map, film reel	type
Date or date range	Exact where known, bracketed estimate where not	date
Incident name and number	The single most valuable access point for a fire unit	subject
Geography	Place name, and coordinates where they can be determined	coverage
People	Named or depicted, with a confidence note where identification is uncertain	subject
Apparatus and resources	Engine, dozer, crew, aircraft designations	subject
Physical format and dimensions	Paper size, print size, film gauge, tape format, reel length	format
Condition	Physical state, and any preservation concern noted	—
Original container and folder	Where it came from and where it went back — provenance is unrecoverable if this is lost	provenance
Scan specification	Resolution, bit depth, color target, equipment, operator, date	—
OCR status	Not applicable, pending, complete, poor quality	—
Review status and approver	Unreviewed, flagged, approved, approved-with-redaction, withheld	—
Rights and access note	Public, internal only, restricted, with the reason	rights

Field	Purpose	Dublin Core
Contributor credit	Who donated or identified it	contributor
Description	Free-text note — what it is, why it matters, what is unclear	description

Uncertainty is recorded rather than hidden — "probably 1961" and "believed to be Battalion 2" are legitimate catalog values, marked as such. And the original container and folder location is never dropped, because it is the only thing that lets a future archivist reconnect a digital record to its physical context.